

I am a second-generation Indian immigrant. My parents came from Chennai to the United States in the early 2000s for education. They met in New Orleans and eventually, had me. When I was two, we moved to Santa Clara, California and when I was four, Fremont, where we lived for the next ten years. Like much of the bay area, Fremont was not particularly culturally diverse, dominated by indians and east asians. And so growing up, both within my family and at school and in the community, I heard a lot about “culture”. For high school and undergrad, we moved to north Dallas (another region with a substantial indian immigrant population), and I continued to hear about the term. In December 2024, I went on a tour of Tamil Nadu through the Tamil Nadu “Reaching Your Roots” program, to learn about what Tamil culture is. This was maybe the most active interaction with culture. Although the program itself had its problems, with the state’s upcoming election politics distracting from the actual purpose of the trip, people talked about preserving and staying true to the Tamil culture.

It doesn’t make much sense to me. Culture is an ever shaping thing. The norms which the people my age share is very different from the norms of my parents, which is very different from their parents.